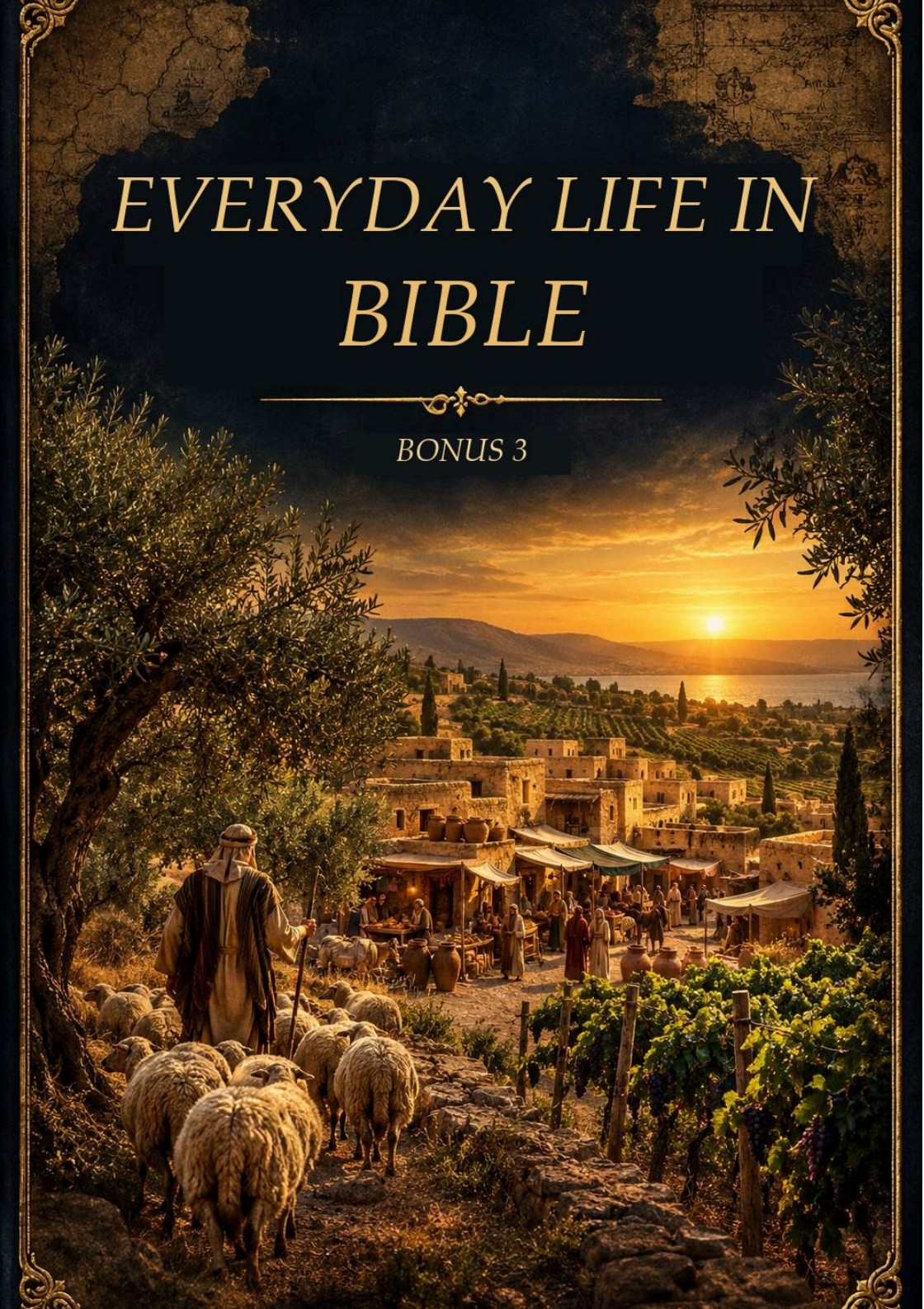
EVERYDAY LIFE IN BIBLE

BONUS 3



BONUS 3

Everyday Life in Biblical Times™

From a mud-brick house to a tomb cut in rock: how the people you read about in the Bible really lived.

When reading the Bible, it is easy to forget that its characters ate real bread, slept in real houses, and walked real roads. They were not figures in a painting but farmers, shepherds, fishermen, craftsmen, and merchants who struggled with drought, taxes, and care for their families. Understanding their daily lives sheds new light on the parables, laws, and stories, because suddenly we see that the images used in them were ordinary and familiar to the first listeners.

This bonus guides you through twelve themes: from home and table, through trades, weddings, and commerce, to roads, school, festivals, and burial. The descriptions draw on archaeological findings and on the biblical texts themselves; where we speak of a reconstruction, it is an artistic interpretation, and dates and figures are given as approximations. With each theme you will find passages worth opening alongside and reading in full.

01

A House in Galilee: From Stone to Roof

1ST CENTURY BC – 1ST CENTURY AD, GALILEE AND JUDEA



Picture an ordinary house from the time of Jesus. It was not a building with many rooms but one main space with a packed-earth floor, walls of rough stone or sun-dried brick, and above them a roof of beams, branches, and a layer of clay. The family ate, worked, and slept in the same room, and often shared it with a few animals that were brought indoors at night to warm the space.

The roof was as important as the room. It was reached by an outside stairway or a ladder, and in time it was covered with clay, which was rolled with a stone roller before the rains so it would not leak. In the evenings it served as a place to rest, dry fruit, and talk, and in summer even to sleep. The Law required a railing around it so no one would fall (Deut 22), and in the story of the paralytic in Capernaum, it is the roof that gets opened up (Mark 2).

- A typical room measured about 4–5 m per side

- Walls of basalt in Galilee, of limestone in Judea
- Light came in through the door and small windows
- An oil lamp often burned all night

WHY WAS THE HOUSE IN CAPERNAUM BLACK?

Houses in Capernaum, on the Sea of Galilee, were built of dark basalt gathered from the surrounding fields. The result was rough but durable. Archaeologists found clusters of houses around shared courtyards, where several related families lived. This arrangement shows that life was communal and that privacy, as we understand it today, barely existed.

02

Bread, Olive Oil, and Wine: What People Ate Every Day

THE WHOLE BIBLICAL ERA

The foundation of the diet was bread, usually barley for the poor and wheat for the better-off. Women ground the grain on stone mills, mixed the dough with water and leaven, and baked flat loaves on heated stones or in a clay oven. Bread was not only eaten but also used as a spoon for dipping into the bowl. No wonder the request for "daily bread" in the Lord's Prayer was a plea for survival itself (Matt 6).

With bread came olive oil, lentils, chickpeas, onions, garlic, figs, dates, grapes, and pomegranates. Meat appeared rarely, mainly at festivals and for guests; fish was more common, especially near the lake, along with dairy, such as cheese and soured milk. Sweetening came from bees' honey or thick syrup of dates and grapes. Wine was diluted with water, and water in cisterns was worth more than gold, especially in the dry season.

- Bread supplied as much as half of daily calories
- Main meals: light at midday, heartier in the evening
- Salt was a cheap but important commodity
- Food was pickled, dried, and salted, since there were no refrigerators

A SIDEBAR ON HOSPITALITY

In the East, hospitality was considered a sacred duty. A guest was welcomed with foot washing, oil, and a bowl of shared food. Refusing to receive a traveler brought shame on the whole family. When Jesus tells of the Good Samaritan or the prodigal son, his listeners understood perfectly how deeply this custom was rooted in their culture.

03

The Shepherd: Life with the Flock

FROM ABRAHAM TO THE TIME OF JESUS



Shepherding was one of the oldest occupations of the people of the Bible. Abraham, Jacob, and David kept flocks, and the image of the shepherd became a symbol of care and leadership. The shepherd led sheep and goats to pasture, guarded them from wolves and lions, searched for water, and counted them in the evening at the entrance to the fold. He used a rod for defense, a staff to guide the flock, and a sling, in which David was a master (1 Sam 16–17).

Life with the flock meant roaming. In winter and spring the flocks stayed on the green slopes of Judea and the Shephelah, in summer they were moved higher or to the rivers, and in the dry season springs had to be found. At night shepherds sheltered the sheep in caves or stone enclosures and slept in the doorway themselves, so that no one could enter without their knowing. This is why Jesus speaks of himself as the gate of the sheep and the good shepherd (John 10).

- Sheep knew the voice of their shepherd
- A fold of stones and thorns protected the flock at night

- Wool was the main product; milk and cheese supplemented the diet
- The shepherds of Bethlehem were among the poorest

SHEPHERDS ON THE NIGHT OF THE NATIVITY

In the Gospel of Luke, the shepherds who were keeping watch over their flock near Bethlehem are the first to learn of the birth of Jesus (Luke 2). Their role is telling: people of low social standing, often viewed with suspicion, become the first witnesses. This contrast shows how the usual hierarchy is turned upside down here.

04

Vineyard, Field, and the Seasons

THE WHOLE FARMING YEAR

Israel lay in a Mediterranean climate, with hot, dry summers and a rainier winter. The early rain in autumn softened the ground for plowing, and the late rain in spring determined the harvest. Barley was harvested in early spring, wheat in May and June, and grapes in August and September. Grain was winnowed on the threshing floor, where the wind separated the chaff, and it was threshed with oxen or heavy sledges. This whole rhythm also set the calendar of festivals.

A vineyard demanded work all year round: pruning the shoots, planting the low walls, building a watchtower and a winepress cut into the rock. Olive trees grew slowly and bore fruit for many generations; the olives were gathered in autumn by beating the branches with sticks. No wonder the prophets and Jesus so often spoke in images of the vineyard, the sower, and the harvest (Isa 5; Matt 13; Matt 20). Their listeners knew them from their own hands.

- Stone terraces held the soil on the slopes
- Winepress: upper vat for treading, lower for the juice
- Drought or locusts meant famine
- The land lay fallow every seventh year (Exod 23)

THE TOWER AND THE WINEPRESS

The landowner in the parable of the vineyard plants it, puts a wall around it, digs a winepress, and builds a tower (Mark 12). This list corresponds exactly to what archaeologists find on the hills of Judea and Samaria: vats cut in rock, stone terraces, and remains of watchmen's huts. The image was not an abstraction, then, but a real landscape that listeners knew by heart.

05

The Fisherman of the Sea of Galilee

1ST CENTURY AD, CAPERNAUM, BETHSAIDA, MAGDALA



The Sea of Galilee, in reality a freshwater lake, was about 21 km long and about 13 km wide, and fishing towns bustled around it: Capernaum, Bethsaida, and Magdala. Fishermen put out in wooden boats with a single sail and oars, most often at night, when the fish rose to the surface. They used casting nets, drag nets, and set nets; after the catch they sat on the shore mending the mesh (Mark 1).

The work was hard and required teamwork. Peter, Andrew, James, and John probably ran family partnerships, hired workers (Mark 1), and paid taxes on their catch. Storms could break out suddenly on the lake, because cold winds from the mountains swept down onto the warm water and raised waves in a matter of moments. That is why the story of the calming of the storm (Mark 4) sounded so realistic to listeners. Fish were dried, salted, and shipped inland.

- In 1986, a 1st-century boat was discovered in the mud near the shore
- The boat was about 8 m long

- Fishing usually lasted from dusk to dawn
- The most common catch was tilapia (the so-called St. Peter's fish)

A BOAT FROM GALILEE

When a drought lowered the water level in 1986, the hull of a wooden boat from the 1st century AD was found on the shore near Magdala. The wood came from several species, and the repairs were numerous, which points to the owner's poverty and long use. We do not know who used it, but it shows what the boats we read about in the Gospels may have looked like.

06

The Craftsman: Carpenter, Potter, Tanner

VILLAGES AND TOWNS OF PALESTINE

Jesus is called the carpenter's son (Matt 13), and the Greek word "tekton" means a craftsman who works in wood, and often in stone as well. His workshop produced farm tools, yokes, doors, roof beams, and furniture. In nearby Sepphoris, a large city being rebuilt during Jesus' youth, there may have been plenty of work for builders. The trade passed from father to son, and training happened by helping in the workshop.

Alongside carpenters worked potters, who fired jugs, bowls, and lamps in kilns; smiths, who worked iron and bronze; stonecutters; weavers and dyers; and tanners, whose work was considered unclean because of contact with animal skins (Acts 9–10). Paul of Tarsus earned his living as a tentmaker (Acts 18), which allowed him to support himself while traveling. In this culture, manual labor was not a disgrace but a sign of dignity and independence.

- The workshop was often next to the house or at the market
- The craftsmen's guild had its own streets in the cities
- A potter's kiln reached about 900°C
- Paul wove tents from goat hair (cilicium)

SEPPHORIS AND NAZARETH

Nazareth lay about 5–6 km from Sepphoris, which under Herod Antipas became the capital of Galilee and received new buildings: streets, a theater, houses. Such close proximity meant a chance to earn money for local craftsmen. The Gospels do not say directly that Joseph and Jesus worked in that city, so it is only a probable backdrop to their lives, not a documented fact.

07

Family and Wedding

THE WHOLE BIBLICAL ERA



The family was the foundation of society. Several generations lived together, the father held authority over the household, and the mother managed the home and the upbringing of the children. Children helped from an early age: boys in the field and workshop, girls in the kitchen and at the loom. Marriages were usually arranged between families, and betrothal was legally binding; Joseph and Mary were “betrothed,” which meant a real commitment, though not yet living together (Matt 1).

A wedding often lasted several days and was the biggest celebration of the local community. The bridegroom, in a procession with burning lamps, went to fetch the bride, the guests feasted, and the master of the feast was responsible for watching over the food and wine. Running out of wine would have been a deeply embarrassing disgrace, which is why the event at Cana (John 2) had practical importance for the hosts. The parable of the ten virgins (Matt 25) draws on the same custom.

- Betrothal usually lasted about a year
- The marriage contract included a dowry and obligations
- A wedding could last as long as 7 days
- An extended family usually numbered a dozen or so people

CANA IN GALILEE

Tradition points to several places that may have been Cana, among them Kafr Kanna and Khirbet Qana. The dispute has not been settled, so we speak of the traditional location. More important than the address is what the story tells us about life at the time: about hospitality, about the pride of the hosts, and about how a wedding brought the whole village together.

08

Coins, Market, and Trade

PERSIAN – ROMAN PERIOD

For centuries, trade relied on the exchange of goods and the weighing of silver, and coins were introduced to the region by the Persians and Greeks. In the time of Jesus, several systems were in circulation: the Roman denarius, a silver coin equal to a laborer's daily wage (Matt 20); the Greek-Phoenician Tyrian shekel, used for Temple payments; and small bronze lepta, the smallest coin, which the widow dropped into the treasury (Mark 12).

The market was the heart of the city. Merchants sold grain, oil, salt, cloth, and vessels, and scales and measures were often rigged, which is why the prophets and the Law so often call for honest weights (Lev 19; Amos 8). Money changing in the Temple was necessary because the Temple tax had to be paid in a specific coin. Taxes were paid to Rome and the Herods, and tax collectors such as Matthew or Zacchaeus were hated (Luke 19).

- Denarius = about a laborer's daily wage
- Lepton = about 1/128 of a denarius
- Customs duties were collected at borders and city gates
- Leather bags and belts served as wallets

THE WIDOW'S MITES

The widow's two lepta were almost worthless in the Temple treasury, where the rich threw in large sums. Jesus draws attention to proportion: the widow gave everything she had (Mark 12). The story shows not only the economy of the age but also an ethic in which what counts is the heart of the giver, not the value of the gift.

09

Roads and Travel

ROMAN PERIOD

People traveled mainly on foot. An ordinary person covered about 25–30 km a day, and the journey from Nazareth to Jerusalem took five to seven days, often by a roundabout route along the Jordan to avoid Samaria. The wealthier rode donkeys, horses served the army, and camels served the caravans. The Romans built a network of paved roads on which legions, couriers, and merchants moved faster; Paul later used these roads as well (Acts 16–28).

Travel was dangerous. Bandits attacked lone travelers, especially on the steep road from Jerusalem to Jericho, described in the parable of the Good Samaritan (Luke 10). Lodging was found in inns, with relatives, or under the open sky. Pilgrims walked in groups, singing the psalms of ascent (Ps 120–134). The sea shortened distances, but storms and shipwrecks, like the one described in Acts 27, were a serious risk.

- The road from Jerusalem to Jericho: about 25 km and a drop of about 1,000 m in elevation
- Pilgrimages to Jerusalem traveled in caravans
- Roman miles were marked with milestones
- A ship could sail about 100–150 km a day with a favorable wind

THE ROMAN ROAD

The Roman road network had primarily military and administrative purposes, but it also helped the early growth of Christianity. Thanks to safer routes and the common Greek language, news could travel from Jerusalem to Rome in a dozen or so years, which helps explain the pace at which the communities described in the Acts of the Apostles spread.

10

School and Synagogue

SECOND TEMPLE PERIOD



Religious education began at home. Parents taught their children prayers, the history of Israel, and the commandments, and boys around five or six years old could begin learning to read the Scriptures. In the rabbinic tradition, learning relied on memory and repetition; students recited passages of the Torah and the Psalms. The more gifted deepened their knowledge with teachers, like Paul, who studied in Jerusalem under Gamaliel (Acts 22).

The synagogue was a place of prayer, Scripture reading, and community gatherings. On the Sabbath a passage from the Torah and the Prophets was read, and any adult man could speak with the permission of the synagogue leader, as Jesus did in Nazareth (Luke 4). The building stood at the center of the town and also served as an assembly hall, a court, and a school. Capernaum had a large synagogue, and the Gospels mention that Jesus often taught in it (Mark 1).

- Scrolls were kept in a special cabinet or chest
- The Torah was read so as to complete the cycle in one year or three

- Hebrew was the language of the liturgy, Aramaic of daily life
- Greek dominated trade and administration

THE READING IN NAZARETH

Luke describes how Jesus stood up in the synagogue, was handed the scroll of the prophet Isaiah, and found the passage and read it (Luke 4). This account gives a good picture of what a service looked like: the scroll was unrolled by hand, the reading was done standing, and the explanation was given sitting. We do not know the full order of the liturgy of that time, but this passage is one of the most valuable testimonies.

11

The Liturgical Year and Festivals

LUNISOLAR CALENDAR

The biblical year was marked by three great pilgrim festivals. Passover, in the month of Nisan, commemorated the exodus from Egypt and was joined to the Feast of Unleavened Bread. Fifty days later came Shavuot, or Pentecost, the festival of the harvest and the giving of the Law. In the autumn came the Feast of Tabernacles, when people lived in booths made of branches in memory of the wandering in the wilderness. Crowds flocked to Jerusalem then from all over the country and from the diaspora (Deut 16).

Besides these there were special days: the Sabbath every seventh day, the new moon, Rosh Hashanah, Yom Kippur (the Day of Atonement, Lev 16), and later festivals such as Hanukkah, commemorating the cleansing of the Temple in the time of the Maccabees. Each festival had its own rites, songs, and foods. The Gospels often set events against the background of these dates, and John records several of Jesus' pilgrimages to Jerusalem (John 2; John 7; John 10).

- Passover: 14 Nisan, in the evening
- Sabbath: from sunset on Friday to sunset on Saturday
- Pentecost: 50 days after Passover
- Tabernacles: seven days of living in booths

A CALENDAR TIED TO THE MOON

Months began with the new moon, so their length was 29 or 30 days. To keep the calendar in line with the seasons, a month was added every few years. That is why the dates of festivals on the solar calendar shifted, as Easter does today. For farmers, it mattered that Passover fell as the barley ripened and Pentecost at the end of the wheat harvest.

12

Clothing, Mourning, and Burial

THE WHOLE BIBLICAL ERA



The basic outfit consisted of a linen or wool tunic, tied with a belt, and a cloak that served as a covering by day and a blanket by night. The Law forbade keeping it overnight as a pledge (Exod 22). On their feet people wore leather sandals. Tassels on the corners of the cloak reminded them of the commandments (Num 15). Women covered their heads with a scarf, and the wealthy wore garments dyed purple from sea snails, which cost a fortune.

Mourning had set signs: tearing the clothes, putting on sackcloth, sprinkling ashes on the head, loud wailing, and often hiring professional mourners (Matt 9). The dead were buried quickly, usually the same day. The body was washed, wrapped in linen with spices, and laid in a tomb cut in rock and closed with a heavy stone. After a year the bones were gathered into an ossuary. This manner of burial explains the description of the tomb of Jesus (John 19–20) and the tomb of Lazarus (John 11).

- The tunic (kuttoneth) reached to the knees or ankles

- Purple garments were dyed with the secretion of Murex snails
- Burial usually took place before sunset
- The stone closing a tomb could be about 1 m in diameter

THE TOMB OF LAZARUS

The story of Lazarus (John 11) shows the whole picture of mourning: wailing women, relatives gathering, a cave tomb closed with a stone, and a body in linen. Bethany was a village above Jerusalem, and many tombs were cut into the rocky slope. This landscape helps us understand why the Gospels speak of a “rolled-away stone” and why moving it took many hands.

SUMMARY

Overview Table

TRADE / ELEMENT OF LIFE		BIBLICAL REFERENCE
House	One room with a packed-earth floor and a flat roof, shared by the family	Mark 2; Deut 22
Shepherd	Leads sheep and goats, protects them, and seeks water	Ps 23; John 10
Farmer and vinedresser	Plowing, sowing, harvest, grape picking, the rhythm of the seasons	Isa 5; Matt 20
Fisherman	Night fishing on the Sea of Galilee from boats and nets	Mark 1; Luke 5
Carpenter	Makes doors, yokes, beams, and furniture	Matt 13; Mark 6
Tentmaker	Work with goat hair, Paul's trade	Acts 18
Wedding	A multi-day feast with a procession and lamps	John 2; Matt 25
Coins	Denarius, lepton, Tyrian shekel	Matt 20; Mark 12
The road to Jericho	A steep, dangerous route for pilgrims	Luke 10
Synagogue	Prayer, Scripture reading, learning	Luke 4; Mark 1
Passover and Tabernacles	Pilgrim festivals commemorating the Exodus	Deut 16; John 7

Burial	Swift burial in a rock tomb closed with a stone	John 11; John 19–20

The next time you open a Gospel, try to picture a cramped room, the smell of oil and baking bread, the heavy nets of the fishermen, and the dust on the road to Jerusalem. Such details do not replace faith or answer every question, but they give the stories depth and the flavor of everyday life. Take one theme from this bonus and read all the passages listed in order; you will find that familiar words sound new.